WEEKLY EPIDEMIOLOGICAL REPORT

A publication of the Epidemiology Unit
Ministry of Health & Mass Media

231, de Saram Place, Colombo 01000, Sri Lanka
Tele: + 94 11 2695112, Fax: +94 11 2696583, E mail: epidunit@sltnet.lk
Epidemiologist: +94 11 2681548, E mail: chepid@sltnet.lk
Web: http://www.epid.gov.lk

WER SRI LANKA 2026

Vol. 53 No. 36 — 31st Aug– 06th Sep 2026

Plague: An Old Disease with a Persistent Presence - I

This is the first article of two in a series on "Plague: An Old Disease with a Persistent Presence "

Introduction

Plague, once the most feared epidemic disease in human history. In fourteenth century, more than one third of Europe, approximately were killed by the bubonic plague or Black Death. The second pandemic of plague in Messina in Sicily was due to Genoese ships carrying flea-laden rats probably from probably from Central Asia and it initiated a huge wave of plague infections across most of Europe (Glatter & Finkelman, 2021) Then the third pandemic began in 1772 in China. and spread worldwide just before the 20th century due to human movement via steamship and railroad (Barbieri et al., 2020) .

It persists in wild rodent populations across Central and East Asia, Africa and the Americas, and continues to cause sporadic human infections every year. In recent, the major outbreaks occured during 2010 and 2015 and resulted more than 600 deaths (Musa et al., 2024) .

In July 2026, It has brought plague back into the Asian spotlight following human bubonic plague case in Khovd Province linked to eating marmot meat and it was confirmed by Mongolia's National Centre for Zoonotic Diseases (NCZD)(Xinhua, 2026). In early October, Russian authorities placed nearly 200 contacts under observation after a 28-year-old laboratory worker at the Irkutsk Anti-Plague Institute in Siberia died of severe pneumonia, reported in the media as pneumonic plague (The Moscow Times, 2026) . As of 8 October 2026, Russia's federal health authority, Rospotrebnadzor, had classified the death as pneumonia of unknown aetiology and had not confirmed plague (Associated Press, 2026).

Sri Lanka has had no human plague was reported from 2019 to 2025 (WHO, 2026). However, there is no published data about last case reported but the risk to the local population remains very low. plague is a class A notifiable disease under the International Health Regulations (IHR 2005).

Causative agent

Plague is a zoonosis caused by *Yersinia pestis*, a non-motile, Gram-negative bacterium. Its survive in the environment relies on the subtle balance between *Y. pestis*-contaminated soils, burrowing and nonburrowing mammals lead to variable degrees of plague susceptibility, and their associated fleas (Barbieri et al., 2020). Plague, a flea-borne zoonosis which the cycles naturally in wild rodents and is primarily transmitted to humans by fleas. The Bubonic plague is the most common following infected flea bites. When untreated and inadequate control measures, may evolve into secondary pneumonic plague which might transmitted rapidly through direct human-to-human as air-borne transmission (Ramasindrazana et al., 2025)

Natural Cycle

The flea life cycle begins when eggs are laid in the moist soil of rodent burrows. The larvae feed on rodent faeces before developing into pupae and adult fleas, which parasitise rodents

1. Strengthening Yellow Fever Preparedness in Sri Lanka: A Public Health Perspective 1
2. Summary of distribution of notified diseases reported by MOH (24th – 30th Aug 2026) 3
3. Surveillance of vaccine preventable diseases & AFP (24th – 30th Aug 2026) 4

and may become infected with Yersinia pestis. In the enzootic cycle, rodents act as hosts and reservoirs of the bacterium, transmitted by fleas such as Xenopsylla cheopis, Xenopsylla brasiliensis, and Synopsyllus fonquerniei. Epizootic cycles occur when plague spreads among susceptible mammals, potentially facilitating its spread to new areas. Humans can become infected through the bites of infected fleas. Furthermore, bubonic plague may progress to pneumonic plague when the lungs are affected, allowing the bacteria to spread through respiratory droplets and cause direct person-to-person transmission (Figure 1) (Alderson et al., 2020).

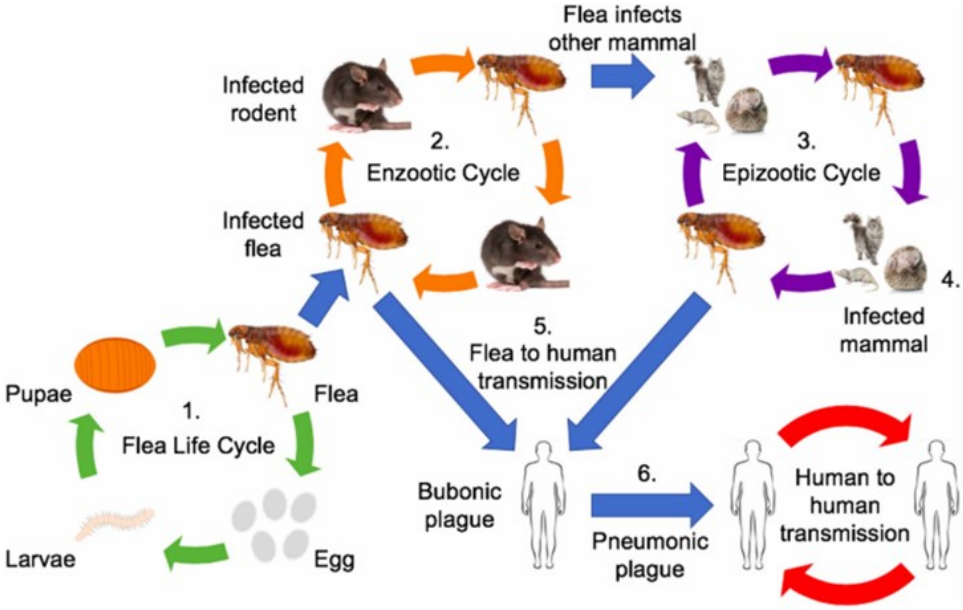


Figure 1: Diagram of plague transmission(Alderson et al., 2020)

Compiled By:

Dr. Poojani Illangasinghe
Senior Registrar in Community Medicine
Epidemiology Unit
Ministry of Health

References:

1. Associated Press. (2026, October 5). Russia reports a worker at a Siberian plague institute got pneumonia from an unknown cause and died. *Courthouse News Service*. https://www.courthousenews.com/russia-reports-a-worker-at-a-siberian-plague-institute-got-pneumonia-from-an-unknown-cause-and-died/
2. Alderson, J., Quastel, M., Wilson, E., & Bellamy, D. (2020). Factors influencing the re-emergence of plague in Madagascar. In *Emerging Topics in Life Sciences* (Vol. 4, Number 4, pp. 423–433). Portland Press Ltd. https://doi.org/10.1042/ETLS20200334
3. Barbieri, R., Signoli, M., Chevé, D., Costedoat, C., Tzortzis, S., Aboudharam, G., Raoult, D., & Drancourt, M. (2020). *Yersinia pestis: the Natural History of Plague*. https://doi.org/10.1128/CMR.00044-19
4. Glatter, K. A., & Finkelman, P. (2021). History of the Plague: An Ancient Pandemic for the Age of COVID-19. In *American Journal of Medicine* (Vol. 134, Number 2, pp. 176–181). Elsevier Inc. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.amjmed.2020.08.019
5. Musa, S. S., Zhao, S., Mkandawire, W., Colubri, A., He, D., Musa, S. S., Zhao, S., Mkandawire, W., Colubri, A., & He, D. (2024). An epidemiological modeling investigation of the long-term changing dynamics of the plague epidemics in Hong Kong. *Mathematical Biosciences and Engineering 2024 10:7435*, *21*(10), 7435–7453. https://doi.org/10.3934/MBE.2024327
6. Ramasindrazana, B., Harimalala, M., Rasoamalala, F., Martin, C. H., Maminirina, L. A., Raritahiry, S. C., Michaux, J., Rajerison, M., Linchant, J., Walter, P., Kassié, D., Guis, H., Keatts, L., & Jori, F. (2025). First assessment of plague in terrestrial small mammals and fleas from Makira Natural Park and surroundings, Northeastern Madagascar. *PLOS Neglected Tropical Diseases*, *19*(11), e0013710. https://doi.org/10.1371/JOURNAL.PNTD.0013710
7. The Moscow Times. (2026). *Nearly 200 People Under Observation After Irkutsk Lab Worker Dies From Plague - The Moscow Times*. https://www.themoscowtimes.com/2026/10/02/nearly-200-people-under-observation-after-irkutsk-lab-worker-dies-from-plague-a93857
8. WHO. (2026). *Plague*. https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/plague
9. Xinhua. (2026). *Suspected bubonic plague case confirmed in Mongolia-Xinhua*. https://english.news.cn/20260725/f0752278561f4d9d9fb305a4acc747da/c.html

 To be Continued….

Table 1: Distribution of Notified Diseases reported by Medical Officers of Health 24th – 30th Aug 2026 (35th Week)

RDHS	Dengue Fever		Dysentery		Encephalitis		En. Fever		F. Poison-		Leptospirosis		Typhus		Viral Hep.		H. Rabies		Chickenpox		Meningitis		Leishman.		Tuberculosis		Leprosy		WRCD	
	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	T*	C**
Colombo	200	19130	0	18	0	2	0	4	0	21	2	233	0	2	0	15	0	0	7	399	0	80	0	4	23	1269	0	117	**28**	**97**
Gampaha	119	15962	0	33	0	34	0	0	0	24	1	366	0	6	0	9	0	0	1	595	1	215	0	39	19	711	3	56	**5**	**74**
Kalutara	111	7664	1	35	0	3	1	11	0	62	11	303	0	9	1	18	0	0	16	638	1	103	0	13	12	390	0	65	**14**	**90**
Kandy	14	6551	0	40	0	9	0	7	0	38	1	146	0	27	0	19	0	0	0	493	0	101	0	43	5	353	0	19	**0**	**100**
Matale	7	2208	0	19	0	5	0	2	0	7	1	154	0	3	0	8	0	0	4	154	0	65	10	376	4	130	0	25	**5**	**89**
Nuwara Eliya	2	1058	0	37	0	5	0	3	0	16	1	217	0	40	0	14	0	0	0	353	0	151	0	2	7	182	0	9	**13**	**100**
Galle	48	6095	1	30	2	13	0	8	1	60	5	413	1	33	1	23	0	0	8	765	3	134	0	2	2	297	2	46	**23**	**89**
Hambantota	26	2765	0	45	0	2	0	0	1	43	3	201	0	26	0	12	0	0	3	171	0	54	18	382	5	100	0	22	**40**	**100**
Matara	12	6426	1	21	0	4	0	2	0	11	3	287	0	17	0	17	0	0	2	399	0	139	0	107	1	106	0	25	**0**	**100**
Jaffna	19	1050	2	70	0	6	0	19	0	95	0	55	1	243	0	1	0	0	0	284	1	42	0	1	0	126	0	12	**100**	**100**
Kilinochchi	1	647	0	12	0	1	0	8	0	1	0	76	0	12	0	3	0	1	0	96	0	14	0	2	3	26	0	2	**60**	**100**
Mannar	1	536	0	1	0	3	0	0	0	3	1	46	0	4	0	3	0	0	0	64	1	21	0	5	1	37	0	5	**17**	**100**
Vavuniya	0	337	0	21	0	4	0	2	0	8	0	102	0	4	0	1	0	0	3	123	0	34	0	23	4	51	0	7	**9**	**83**
Mullaitivu	1	104	0	6	0	2	0	1	0	13	0	35	0	6	0	2	0	0	1	13	0	10	0	10	4	23	0	7	**0**	**100**
Batticaloa	19	1550	2	66	2	14	0	2	0	21	2	146	0	2	0	16	0	0	5	250	0	74	0	22	4	112	2	83	**56**	**100**
Ampara	18	655	0	53	0	1	0	1	0	16	4	128	0	2	0	16	0	0	8	275	0	63	0	17	1	40	2	21	**7**	**100**
Trincomalee	5	751	1	24	0	6	0	2	0	15	1	79	0	8	0	4	0	0	4	188	0	31	0	18	0	102	0	7	**100**	**100**
Kurunegala	24	3400	0	22	0	18	0	3	0	66	2	315	1	30	0	13	0	1	6	608	3	296	3	329	4	221	0	51	**11**	**99**
Puttalam	16	1869	0	18	0	11	0	0	0	9	1	197	1	26	0	7	0	4	0	126	0	139	0	15	14	125	0	23	**11**	**91**
Anuradhapura	29	1111	0	19	0	9	0	3	0	51	3	202	0	26	0	13	0	0	6	437	3	124	4	572	2	186	1	50	**13**	**100**
Polonnaruwa	8	824	0	25	0	7	0	2	0	59	0	225	0	7	0	25	0	1	2	381	0	57	3	393	0	60	0	67	**0**	**90**
Badulla	22	1700	0	33	0	8	0	3	0	13	2	204	1	42	0	118	0	0	2	335	2	205	0	93	3	175	0	15	**5**	**100**
Monaragala	10	1269	0	15	0	3	0	2	0	10	2	225	1	30	0	52	0	1	0	189	4	86	1	170	3	93	1	19	**45**	**82**
Ratnapura	44	5285	1	30	0	7	0	7	0	19	11	690	0	31	0	14	0	0	2	290	0	86	2	159	6	286	2	30	**7**	**97**
Kegalle	24	2764	0	46	0	6	0	5	3	28	5	316	0	11	0	12	0	0	16	561	0	78	0	13	7	223	0	9	**11**	**93**
Kalmunai	9	1029	1	44	0	3	0	1	2	22	1	63	0	1	0	3	0	0	5	380	0	36	0	0	0	84	0	26	**6**	**100**
SRILANKA	**789**	**92740**	**10**	**783**	**4**	**186**	**1**	**98**	**7**	**731**	**63**	**5424**	**6**	**648**	**2**	**438**	**0**	**8**	**101**	**8567**	**19**	**2438**	**41**	**2810**	**134**	**5508**	**13**	**818**	**22**	**95**

Source: WRCD module of the EPINET.
A = Cases reported during the current week;
T*=Timeliness refers to returns received on or before 30th Aug, 2026.
B = Cumulative cases for the year.
Total number of reporting units 363
C**-Completeness;
C**-Completeness;

Table 2: Selected Vaccine Preventable Diseases & AFP **24th – 30th Aug 2026 (35th Week)**

Disease	No. of Cases by Province									Number of cases during current week in 2026	Number of cases during same week in 2025	Total number of cases to date in 2026	Total number of cases to date in 2025	Difference between the number of cases to date in 2026 & 2025
	W	C	S	N	E	NW	NC	U	Sab					
AFP[1]	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	42	43	-2.3%
Diphtheria	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	0 %
Mumps[2]	00	00	00	00	01	01	00	00	00	02	01	103	104	-0.9%
Measles[3]	00	01	00	00	00	03	01	00	00	05	00	56	02	2700 %
Rubella[3]	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	0 %
CRS[2]	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	0 %
Tetanus[2]	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	01	04	04	0 %
Neonatal Tetanus[2]	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	0 %
Japanese Encephalitis[3]	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	00	01	00	04	-100 %
Whooping Cough[2]	00	00	01	00	00	00	00	00	00	01	01	21	16	31.2 %

Key to Table 2

Provinces: **W**: Western, **C**: Central, **S**: Southern, **N**: North, **E**: East, **NC**: North Central, **NW**: North Western, **U**: Uva, **Sab**: Sabaragamuwa.

Data Sources:
Weekly Return of Communicable Diseases: Diphtheria, Mumps, Tetanus, Neonatal Tetanus, Whooping Cough.
Special Surveillance: AFP, Measles, Rubella, CRS.

AFP[1] = No Polio cases
Mumps[2], CRS[2], Tetanus[2], Neonatal Tetanus[2], Whooping Cough[2]—Clinically and/ or laboratory confirmed cases
Measles[3], Rubella[3], Japanese Encephalitis[3]— Laboratory Confirmed cases

AFP—Acute Flaccid Paralysis
CRS = Congenital Rubella Syndrome
NA = Not Available

AFP and all Vaccine Preventable Diseases should be investigated by the MOH Personally.

All patients presenting with fever and a maculopapular rash must be promptly notified and investigated. Blood samples and throat swabs should be collected at the appropriate time window

Comments and contributions for publication in the WER Sri Lanka are welcome. However, the editor reserves the right to accept or reject items for publication. All correspondence should be mailed to The Editor, WER Sri Lanka, Epidemiology Unit, P.O. Box 1567, Colombo or sent by E-mail to **chepid@sltnet.lk.** The Epidemiology Unit should be formally acknowledged in all resulting publications as the primary data source.

How to cite: Epidemiology Unit, Ministry of Health, Sri Lanka. (Year). Weekly Epidemiological Report, Vol. [Volume Number], No. [Issue Number, Page numbers].

ON STATE SERVICE

Dr. Palitha Karunapema
CHIEF EPIDEMIOLOGIST
EPIDEMIOLOGY UNIT
231, DE SARAM PLACE
COLOMBO 10